



Meroë Pyramids

A collection of more than 200 pyramids built over the royal tombs of the Kingdom of Kush

From the 8th century BCE, the Kingdom of Kush ruled over Nubia, the land along the Nile south of Egypt, for almost 900 years. Meroë, in present-day Sudan, was chosen as the capital of this empire in the 3rd century BCE, and through trade—especially in ironware and ceramics—became established as a prosperous city, as well as the home of the royal family.

The Kingdom of Kush developed a distinctive civilization in parallel with that of neighboring Egypt while incorporating some elements of Egyptian culture, most conspicuously the construction of pyramids over the tombs of their rulers and prominent citizens. These can be seen today in three excavated cemetery sites around the town of Meroë, where many of the Meroite rulers are buried.

Nubian outline

The Meroë pyramids are recognizably different from the more famous ones at Giza in Egypt (see pp.208–209), with a characteristically Nubian steep-sided shape and often an imposing entrance structure. Although not as massive as the Egyptian pyramids, the sheer number of pyramids in close proximity in the Meroë burial sites makes an equally impressive sight.

The burial chambers beneath the pyramids originally housed the remains and funerary goods of the royalty of Kush, and they were decorated with paintings, relief carvings, and hieroglyphics showing Egyptian influence. Unfortunately, the tombs have been repeatedly raided over the ages, and little of the treasure they contained has survived to modern times.



△ NUBIAN JEWELRY

Among the goods found in the tombs were many items of jewelry, including this gold and enamel hinged bracelet decorated with an image of the goddess Hathor and geometric patterns.

DESTRUCTION AND REBUILDING

Of the more than 200 pyramids at Meroë, many were partially dismantled in Italian explorer Giuseppe Ferlini's search for treasure. However, some, such as those in the foreground of this image, have been fully reconstructed.

